

A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z

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Achievements

Achievements are milestones in the Network [client journey](#). They capture the significant positive outcome of advisory and [partnering services](#) provided to [clients](#). Achievements are recorded in the Achievements database.

We distinguish between [Advisory Achievement](#) and [Partnering Achievement](#). Achievements are one of the Network's KPIs ([KPI3](#)).

A client with no [Action Plan](#) yet but involved in an Achievement can be counted under [KPI2](#).

Access to funding and finance

Access to funding and finance services (A2F) focus on helping SMEs access the funding they need to innovate and grow internationally. They include advice on different types of EU funding programmes likely to be relevant to a client's needs to help them achieve the goals supported in the [client journey](#), such as InvestEU, Horizon Europe, Innovation Fund, European Regional Development Funds, European Structural and Investment Fund (ESIF) programmes, and funds under national Recovery and Resilience Plans. These services include general awareness-raising events, competence building hands-on workshops focusing on how to prepare high quality proposals, [partnering services](#) to identify suitable project partners, as well as one-to-one support during the partnering/application process.

Network A2F services also include supporting SMEs seeking funding from other sources of finance, including banks, public finance schemes, venture capital, seed capital and business angels, and alternative sources of finance like crowdfunding.

A2F services can include complex services focusing on individual investment readiness programmes, business planning, pitching techniques and partnership activities to put SMEs into contact with potential investors. The scope to provide these services may depend on national legislation.

Action plan

In the Network client journey the action plan describes, starting from the needs assessment, the concrete actions of the hub and all the foreseen touchpoints (interactions) between the client and the [spokes](#) to respond to the identified need. It contains information on the actors and the objectives and sets deadlines for completion of the services. Once agreed with the client, the action plan must be registered in the EEN Community.

Only [clients](#) with Action Plans or involved in [Achievements](#) can be counted under [KPI2](#).

Advisory Achievements

Advisory Achievements (AAs) result from advanced [advisory services](#). They are carried out by one or more Network partners leading to a significant positive outcome for the client.

AAs facilitate and consequently mark the successful entry to market or international presence of a Network client in an EU Member State other than the one it is based in, or in an SMP associated country, or in one of the Network's international partners' countries, or to other measurable improvements such as access to funding/finance, significant capacity improvements, better resilience, or [sustainability](#), etc. The result of the service is associated with considerable, measurable and/or identifiable [impact](#) for the client.

Individual [SME feedback](#) provided to the European Commission via the appropriate feedback mechanism after the Network has provided advanced one-to-one services can also generate AAs, provided that the individual [SME feedback](#) cases are recorded in the SME feedback database, a European Business Test Panel or dealt with through [SOLVIT](#) and are recorded as such in the Network's IT platform. There must be a demonstrable immediate or long-term [impact](#) (either because of a solution to a problem or a long-term benefit such as informing the legislative or regulatory process).

Advisory Achievements are [KPI3a](#).

Advisory service

Advisory services aim at increasing sustainable growth, competitiveness, and/or resilience of individual [clients](#). They must relate to one or more thematic or sectoral priority areas of the Network.

They may include capacity building services, such as coaching and training, to increase [clients'](#) skills for [sustainability](#), [innovation](#), resilience and adaptability to new economic conditions, [digitalisation](#), [internationalisation](#), and other priority areas.

Furthermore, advisory services may aim at helping individual Network [clients](#) access relevant EU funding programmes, finance and other support mechanisms.

Advisory services should lead to measurable and/or identifiable [impact](#) for the client.

In the [client journey](#), advisory services carried out by one or more Network partners leading to a positive outcome for the client result in [Advisory Achievements](#) (AAs).

Annual Guidance Note

Policy document drafted by the European Commission's Directorate General for Internal Market, Industry, Entrepreneurship and SMEs ([DG GROW](#)) defining the key political priorities for the Enterprise Europe Network for the coming year.

B

Brokerage services / events

Brokerage events (also matchmaking, business speed dating or B2B events) are a series of pre-arranged transnational meetings organised at a single venue for SMEs. They are often arranged at trade shows, fairs, exhibitions or conferences, but can also be stand-alone events.

Brokerage events is the great opportunity to meet potential cooperation partners and make new contacts. Participants meet during facilitated face-to-face meetings (usually 20-30 minutes), where they can explore potential business and technological cooperation opportunities. B2B meetings are sometimes held both face to face and online.

C

Capacity-building for SMEs

Capacity building services for SMEs provided by the Network include coaching and training, to increase [clients](#)' skills for [sustainability](#), [innovation](#), resilience and adaptability to new economic conditions, [digitalisation](#), internationalisation, and other priority areas.

Centralised / decentralised training

"Centralised" training courses are events organised by [EISMEA](#) ("the Agency")/[DG GROW](#) or other EU institutions for (staff members of) the Network. It can be organised in online, hybrid or onsite in Brussels.

"Decentralised" training courses are supported and approved by the Agency but organised by Network partners and take place online, onsite in the country/city of the organising Network partner or hybrid. They must be open to all other Network partners (within the limits of the space available).

Client card

In the EEN Community's Clients section, a client card contains all the information related to a client receiving [Network services](#), including company information, contact person(s), and history of services provided by the Network ([Client Journey](#)).

A client card can be easily shared with other Network advisors who are involved in supporting the client.

Client-centric approach

The Network's client-centric approach implies designing the services from the client's perspective where a focal point is identifying the needs and following up of the individual client. The approach aims at creating positive experience for companies by maximising quality, building relationships and reaching a concrete success for the SMEs in terms of [impact](#).

Client journey

The client journey is the company's growth path realised with the help of the [Network services](#). The client journey in the Network is associated with the provision of advanced Network services (see [Network services](#)). The client journey is visible in the EEN Community on the Client Card, where all advanced services provided to a client are recorded.

Company mission

A mission with one or more [Network clients](#) visiting and meeting one or more [Network clients](#) from a different country with a view to establishing a partnership.

Communication Champion / correspondent

Each consortium needs to identify one communication correspondent. In countries with only one consortium, the communication correspondent is also nominated as Champion. In countries with more than one consortium, out of the several consortium communication correspondents, one is nominated by the national coordinator as Champion. To be nominated as Champions, Network advisers need to have at least two years of experience in communication.

Communication strategy

A strategy provides guidance for communication activities for an entire framework period. It is an overarching document that drives concrete actions. It identifies objectives, messages, target audiences, channels, tools and monitoring and evaluation techniques.

Communication workplan

A communication workplan is a list of concrete activities developed to ensure the achievement of the communication objectives laid out in a communication strategy. It has a defined duration in time, usually 1 year, and it encompasses diverse actions such as specific events and campaigns. Each consortium creates their own communication workplan.

Consortium

A group of host organisations joining their respective expertise in a given country or region to provide all required services under the Enterprise Europe Network, who agree to submit a joint proposal and carry out all proposed activities in collaboration with each other (provided the proposal is accepted).



DG GROW

Directorate General for Internal Market, Industry, Entrepreneurship and SMEs is the Commission department that works to support an open, seamless and resilient [Single Market](#), with open borders and free flow of goods and services. It is the Directorate General in charge of the Enterprise Europe Network.

Digitalisation

Network digitalisation support services to SMEs aim to help in their transition to more digital business models by applying and integrating digital technologies to improve their efficiency (such as artificial intelligence tools, internet of things, e-commerce, 5G, quantum computing, etc.).

Network consortia are expected to use of the [hub-and-spoke](#) model to make digitalisation support services available to companies through collaboration with other consortia or [external stakeholders](#), especially European Digital Innovation Hubs (EDIH) and digital clusters.

Network digitalisation support services include:

Raising awareness amongst SMEs on the challenges and opportunities of digital technologies to improve their business models, and the support available for them to uptake such technologies.

Carrying out basic digitalisation assessments to help SMEs understand how to better implement their digital transformation, ranging from basic solutions such as e-commerce to more advanced solutions such as application of Artificial Intelligence. Digitalisation assessments can be done using the Digital Maturity Assessment (DMA) Tool of EDIH or other assessment tools.

Providing related services that further support SMEs in their digital transformation, such as advice on access to finance, partnering and [technology transfer](#) services, advice on EU legislation and standards, etc.

In the delivery of these services, Network consortia are expected to collaborate with EDIH and digital clusters, where relevant, for the success of their [clients' client journey](#). Network consortia should facilitate cross-border cooperation between their [clients](#) and the clients

of EDIH, serve EDIH clients with specialised services such as the ones on [internationalisation](#), organise joint B2B events, investor-related events, and hackathons with EDIH and digital clusters. For their collaboration with EDIH and digital clusters, Network consortia are invited to use the principles presented in the “[Cooperation Guidelines for a seamless digitalisation support to European SMEs](#).”



EEN Community

The EEN Community is the Enterprise Europe Network’s IT platform and contains three main modules: COMMUNITY, CONNECT and LEARN.

COMMUNITY provides support to Network advisors in their day-to-day work to provide services to [network clients](#). It is the general business tool of the EEN for their customer relationship management ([CRM](#)). It contains the client cards and action plans. It is also the place where all information is gathered about organised brokerage events and [digitalisation](#) as well as the partnering opportunities (drafting + dissemination).

CONNECT is the Network’s collaborative space, to exchange ideas, share information, and initiate discussions. CONNECT contains workspaces, and Network advisors can become a member of the workspaces that interest them. All [Sector Groups](#) and [Thematic Groups](#) of the Network have a workspace in CONNECT.

LEARN is the Network’s centralised learning and training platform.

EEN2EIC

Support to European Innovation Council (EIC) Accelerator by the Enterprise Europe Network

The EEN2EIC is a project funded under the Horizon Europe (EIC WP 2031), its objective is to empower EEN network offices to support potential EIC applicants, specifically women entrepreneurs, applicants from widening countries, and Seal of Excellence (SoE) holders. EEN2EIC overall objective is to make EU innovation support more efficient by improving the capacity of SMEs to apply to the EIC and by helping SoE holders finance their projects and to avoid overlapping with [National Contact Points](#)’ (NCPs) activities.

To know more about the project, the support mechanism, and the events:

<https://een2eic.eu/>

EISMEA

The European Innovation Council and SMEs Executive Agency manages several EU funding programmes focusing on SME support, [innovation](#) and the [Single Market](#).

<https://eisma.ec.europa.eu/>

EU Academy

The EU Academy is the EU's corporate e-learning tool. Any EU institution, service or agency can use it to host their pedagogical contents for external audiences to follow.

The Enterprise Europe Network will use the EU Academy to provide e-learning tracks and online training courses for Network advisors and for external audiences such as [stakeholders](#) and [clients](#).

To know more about EU Academy: <https://academy.europa.eu/>



Financial & non-financial contractual terms

All financial and non-financial terms used in the Funding & Tender portal and in the contracts that each consortium signs with EISMEA can be found on the “Guidance & Manuals” page of the Funding & Tender portal under “[Glossary](#)”.



Horizon Europe

Horizon Europe is the biggest EU Research and Innovation programme ever with funding available over 7 years (2021 to 2027) for research, development and innovation projects.

For more information: https://ec.europa.eu/info/horizon-europe_en

Host organisation

The legal entity which carries out the Network activities and in which the department/group of staff members assigned to this activity are employed or engaged.

Hub

In the Network, the local hub is the entity that employs the Network advisor who plays the role of a case manager for the client: providing needs assessment and following the entire journey of the client into the Network ecosystem, checking the outputs, outcomes and [impact](#) of the journey for the client.

Hub-and-spoke model

The Hub-and-spoke model is a network structure in which several Network partners and, when needed and possible, other [stakeholders](#) outside of the Network, pool their resources together to contribute to one central goal. A key application of the hub-and-spoke model is to pool the expertise of several Network advisors, from the same

consortium or from different consortia and/or countries to provide a service to an EEN client under the supervision of the client's main contact point in the Network or '[hub](#)'. The other contributing organisations are the '[spokes](#)'.

The hub-and-spoke model ensures that Network partners make the best use of their resources and work better together to use and share services across the Network and across the local, regional, national and/or the EU ecosystem.

The hub-and-spoke model brings together knowledge, excellence and competence to deal with the complex challenges [Network clients](#) face. It brings at the forefront the Network effect as enabler deriving from the connection of partners.



Impact

Impact is associated with a client's financial growth and will be measured in terms of increased market share, increased turnover, optimised costs or realised savings in international activities, job creation or maintenance, improved quality of products, services or processes, introduced product or service innovations related to international activities.

Impact assessment

In the Network's [client journey](#), the impact assessment is a cumulative measurement providing an overview of all impact achieved throughout the span of the individual action plans in a [client's journey](#). Impact assessment is obtained from [clients](#) by Network advisors and recorded in a yearly EEN Impact Survey. The impact survey is open the whole year and can be either filled in directly by the client or by a Network adviser on its behalf.

International Network Partner – INP

International Network Partners (INPs) are organisations based neither in EU member states nor in countries associated to the Single Market Programme. They do not receive financing from the EU but use their own financial resources to participate in the Enterprise Europe Network. Information on INPs can be found in the Internationalisation Thematic Group workspace in [CONNECT](#).

Innovation

Network research, innovation and [technology transfer](#) support services to SMEs aim to help them increase their competitive position by increasing their innovation capacities.

They include:

Innovation (management) capacity building services with a particular focus on [digitalisation](#) and [sustainability](#), utilising certified tools for innovation (management) audits. This service may include an innovation (management) capacity assessment, a gap analysis and the provision of targeted services to address recognised gaps;

Cooperating with Horizon Europe [National Contact Points](#) (HE NCPs) Coordinators and thematic HE NCPs networks to identify and exploit complementarities and synergies;

Monitoring and informing SMEs about EU funding opportunities for innovation activities from Horizon Europe and other relevant sources and ensure – in cooperation with other networks such as the HE NCPs where relevant;

Organising in-depth competence-building workshops for SMEs on the European Innovation Council (EIC) Accelerator and other relevant opportunities within Horizon Europe, EUREKA, the EU Innovation Fund, and others;

Providing [technology transfer](#) services to facilitate the brokerage of transnational [technology transfer](#) agreements. [Technology transfer](#) activities may also support research intensive SMEs throughout the innovation process leading up to the commercialisation of products, processes and services;

Rising awareness on intellectual property issues and provide support to facilitate the use of IP rights and help SMEs trade and exploit their intellectual assets at international level, including by cooperating with the European IP Helpdesk and the international IP Helpdesks to give SMEs access to their IP services (including joint training events and mutual signposting of [clients](#)). IP services can also be provided through on collaboration agreements with other providers outside the consortium.

Internationalisation

Network internationalisation support services aim at helping relevant SMEs to benefit from the opportunities of international trade, [technology transfer](#), as well as research and [innovation](#) cooperation with [third countries](#) outside the [Single Market](#). This includes helping SMEs in making use of EU Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) and overcoming barriers to trade and participation in international public procurement projects.

This implies providing:

- Support to help companies access [third countries](#)' markets through business matchmaking activities and [advisory services](#) supporting the partnering

- process, focusing for example on market intelligence, identification of suitable growth markets, local business conditions, and on capacity building for SMEs;
- Tailor-made services to overcome barriers to the internationalisation of innovation-oriented and technology-driven European SMEs with high-growth potential and help them scale up their activities in [third countries](#);
 - Support to SMEs on trade related issues for better exploitation of business opportunities offered by new or existing EU trade and economic partnership agreements;
 - Collaboration with [International Network Partners](#) in [third countries](#) to better support [clients](#)' access to [third country](#) markets.

K

KPI

KPI1. SMEs served by Enterprise Europe Network

KPI1 counts the number of SMEs receiving any kind of [service](#), **basic and/or advanced**, including **one-to-one**, **one-to-few** and **one-to-many**.

This indicator counts the companies served by the Network under the '[no-wrong-door](#)' principle. It captures the Network's outreach within the SME community in the geographical area covered by the consortium. It measures the number of SMEs that have been in contact with the Network in any capacity, regardless of characteristics like effort, duration, or [impact](#).

In the Network [client journey](#), KPI1 is linked to the entry point of the interaction with all companies. Some of the SMEs counted in this indicator will continue in the [client journey](#) becoming [returning or repeat clients](#).

For reporting, KPI one data comes from Network partners' own [CRM](#) systems.

KPI2. Unique clients in the Network client journey

KPI2 counts the number of unique Network clients receiving tailor-made [advanced services](#) based on needs assessment and drafted action plan. These are typically customised one-to-one and one-to-few in-depth services to companies that have already started their [client journey](#).

The indicator measures how many [clients](#) get active, strong, continuous Network support.

In the Network [client journey](#), the SMEs counted here are [returning clients](#), who often turn into [repeat clients](#). The support requires close ties with and deep knowledge of the client developed in both initial and regularly updated needs assessment, supported by a detailed action plan to maximise the positive [impact](#) on its business.

KPI2 captures the Network's **effective client base** receiving value-added and impact-driven support through advanced services. It is a subset of KPI1. In contrast to KPI1, KPI2 includes only advanced services provided during the client journey.

All services delivered to [clients](#) in KPI2 are aiming at Achievements (KPI3) – advisory or partnering – and a positive [impact](#) for the client in a short- and/or long-term perspective.

KPI3. Achievements

KPI3 counts the number of Achievements from Network advisory and [partnering services](#). They result from tailor-made **advanced**, **one-to-one** and **one-to-few** in-depth services with considerable, measurable and/or identifiable [impact](#) for the client.

[Impact](#) is associated with the company's financial growth: increased market share, increased turnover, optimised costs or realised savings in international activities, job creation or maintenance, improved quality of products, services or processes, introduced product or service innovations related to international activities.

KPI3 captures the outcome of the Network support to [clients](#). [Achievements](#) can be reached with the participation of one or more Network partners ([hub and spoke model](#)) and are reported by both. They have a clear international dimension and capitalise on the Network effect.

In the Network client journey, [Achievements](#) are milestones for the [clients](#) counted under KPI2.

KPI3a. Advisory Achievements

Advisory Achievements (AAs) result from advanced [advisory services](#). They are carried out by one or more Network partners leading to a significant positive outcome for the client.

AAs facilitate and consequently mark the successful entry to market or international presence of a Network client in an EU Member State other than the one it is based or in a SMP associated country, or in one of the Network's international partners' countries.

The result of the service is associated with considerable, measurable and/or identifiable [impact](#) for the client.

KPI3b. Partnering Achievements

Partnering Achievements (PAs) result from [partnering services](#). They are carried out by one or more Network partners leading to a significant positive outcome for the clients concerned.

PAs mark the successful conclusion of a concrete medium- to long-term collaboration between two Network clients located in different EU Member States, SMP associated

countries or in a country of one of the Network's international partners¹. The result of this collaboration is associated with considerable, measurable and/or identifiable [impact](#) for the client.

In specific cases and always in the interest of the client, PAs can be concluded between a Network client and a company or organisation that are not Network clients (yet). These single-party PAs cannot exceed 20% of all PAs of a consortium².

KPI4. Unique clients with an impact assessed in their client journey

KPI4 counts the number of unique clients that have received a series of tailor-made advanced services and completed an [impact assessment](#), which showed clear evidence of important benefit for the client.

KPI4 captures the **long-term impact** of the Network support to clients.

[Impact](#) is associated with the company's financial growth: increased market share, increased turnover, optimised costs or realised savings in international activities, job creation or maintenance, improved quality of products, services or processes, introduced product or service innovations related to international activities.

The [impact assessment](#) is conducted by the Network partner acting as the hub according to an **impact assessment questionnaire**, which will be made available by the Agency. It will measure the positive effects of the Network's services on the SME clients provided by Network partners in the following areas:

- Business development;
- Financial development;
- Organisational development;
- Cooperation development.

The questionnaire must also gather information about the client satisfaction from the provided services.

The encoding and proceeding with the [impact assessment](#) questionnaire will be through the Network IT platform ensuring measurement of the cumulative impact of advanced services in a certain timeframe for every unique client.

¹ In the latter case, one of the Network clients concluding the partnership should be based in the EU or in a SMP associated country.

² In single-party PAs with participation of non-EEN countries, the cooperation with the country should be identified in the work programme of the consortium or, if not, it should be explicitly approved in advance by the Agency.

M

Mentoring

A mentor is a Network advisor that has the necessary experience in the Network and in particular in-depth knowledge about [Network services](#). The role of the mentor is to facilitate the integration of less experienced members of the Network and to offer practical advice related to daily operational issues. Experienced Network advisors can apply to become mentor via an [EU Survey form](#). The list of approved mentors can be found on CONNECT > TG Quality L&D workspace > Library.

In particular newcomers and [International Network Partners](#), can apply to be mentored and become a mentee. When choosing a mentor, it is recommended that clients of the mentor organisation have business interests in the region where the newcomer (mentee) is located.

Mentors and Mentees agree on the topic(s), terms, duration and roles of those taking part in the mentoring and formulate a Mentoring Plan. After an informal agreement mentor and mentee can officialise their mentoring scheme via the dedicated online form on LEARN where it will be approved by [EISMEA](#).

N

National Contact Points (NCP)

The National Contact Points are the main structure to provide guidance, practical information, and assistance on all aspects of participation in Horizon Europe. NCPs are national structures established and financed by governments of the 27 EU Member States and the states associated to the research framework programme. The NCP systems can vary from one country to another from highly centralised to decentralised networks, and be hosted by very different actors, from ministries to universities, research centres and special agencies to private consulting companies.

Needs assessment

In the Network client journey, the starting point of the client journey is to assess the needs and capacity of the client as well as the ability of the individual partner to assist with the identified needs and if not, signpost the client to another Network partner or local [stakeholders](#).

Network advisors

Staff members from host organisations participating in Network consortia that provide value-added advisory and [partnering services](#) to clients.

Network clients

Any SME/organisation receiving a service from one or more Network partners. Clients should be part of the [target group](#) of the Network.

Depending on the level of interaction with the Network, clients can be:

- *Unique clients*: those Network clients are counted once in a given timeframe. They cannot be counted again, no matter how many times they revisit the services;
- *Returning clients*: the clients who have interacted with the Network and turn to it again, at least once more;
- *Repeat clients*: the Network's most loyal clients who return to the Network for services time and time again.

Network effect

The Network effect is the enabler deriving from the connection of partners. By sharing information, resources, activities, and competences of several Network partners which supporting each other and jointly serve SMEs a higher [impact](#) is achieved compared to working alone.

This effect is primarily based on the principles of cooperative behaviour and the fact that the organisations in the Network are equally concerned about the [impact](#) and success of their fellow partner organisations as they are of their own and want to obtain the best outcome for the clients.

Network members

Any member of a consortium.

Network partners

The units / departments / operational teams within the host organisations that implement the activities of the Enterprise Europe Network.

Network services

Services provided by Network advisors to the [target group](#) of the Network within the support framework (client journey, [hub-and-spoke](#) model).

Depending on the complexity of the request, the need to tailor and the effort to address it, Network services are categorised as:

- *Basic Network services* give direct and straightforward solutions to a company's problem, so that the company does not need further assistance on the specific query. Often short-term in nature, basic services are standard; they are not specifically customised and provide off-the-shelf solutions to companies;

- *Advanced Network services* support clients facing more complex issues or barriers and help them prepare for realisation of their medium- and longer-term business plans. When basic services are not sufficient to provide a direct (off-the-shelf or standard) solution to a company's problem, Network partners can propose advanced services, tailored to the specific needs of the company.

Depending on the relationship between the Network advisor and the client, Network services can be:

- *One-to-many*: services offered to large groups of clients (referrals to webpages; general seminars, etc.);
- *One-to-few*: services offered to a limited defined group of clients (dedicated workshops to specific target groups e.g. scale-ups, sectors, etc.);
- *One-to-one*: individual services delivered to one single client.

No-wrong-door principle

The no-wrong-door principle is one of the key standards of Enterprise Europe Network and entails the implementation of an effective mechanism for signposting towards other providers of services in their consortium or region, for the benefit of all clients. The aim is to ensure that all services of the Network are accessible via any Network partner (even if not provided by themselves), and that the Network can act as a gateway to the entire SME support system for their clients.

NUTS

The abbreviation NUTS stands for nomenclature of territorial units for statistics. It is a hierarchical system for dividing up the economic territory of the European Union and is used in EU (regional) statistics, socio-economic analyses of the regions and the framing of EU policies, in particular the regional policy.

For more information: <https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/web/nuts/background>.



Partnering Achievements

Partnering Achievements (PAs) result from [partnering services](#). They are carried out by one or more Network partners leading to a significant positive outcome for the clients concerned.

PAs mark the successful conclusion of a concrete medium- to long-term collaboration between two Network clients located in different countries addressed by the Network or a Network client's inclusion in a consortium for a collaborative project under an EU R&D or innovation programme. The result of this collaboration is associated with considerable, measurable and/or identifiable [impact](#) for the client.

In specific cases and always in the interest of the client, PAs can be concluded between a Network client and a company or organisation that are not Network clients (yet).

Partnering profile

All requests and offers for partnerships of Network clients are recorded in the so-called "partnering profiles opportunities database". They outline the type (offers or requests), objective and potential outcome of the desired partnership that the Network client aims to achieve.

Partnering profiles are created in the partnering process when Network advisors seek to identify suitable partnering opportunities for their clients abroad.

A partnering profile is a cooperation request or offer. It summarises essential information about the nature of the client, the partner they are looking for and the expected cooperation. There are 5 profile types: Business Offers (BO), Business Requests (BR), Technology Offers (TO), Technology Requests (TR) and Research & Development Requests (RDR).

More details on each type of profile and how to draft them can be found in the [Partnering Profile Quality Guidelines](#).

Partnering Opportunities Database – POD

The Partnering Opportunities Database – POD contains thousands of business, technology and research cooperation requests and offers from companies and research and development institutions. Network partners and their clients can subscribe to receive alerts on new requests and offers. Network partners can post offers and requests in the POD by following the [Partnering Profiles Quality Guidelines](#).

Partnering Services

Partnering services include all types of international brokerage and matchmaking services with the aim to generate SMEs' sustainable growth through international business and technical collaborations between Network partners' clients. The aim is to help clients of the Network engage in establishing successful partnerships in:

- Business / commercial collaboration;
- [Innovation](#) / technology and knowledge transfer;
- Collaboration fostering R&D activities of SMEs and aiming at participation of SMEs in European research and innovation programmes.

The Network's assistance covers the entire partnering process, from the identification of suitable partnering opportunities to accompanying [advisory services](#) and assistance to ensure a successful entry into the target market(s) or sector(s).

In the client journey, partnering services carried out by one or more Network partners leading to a significant positive outcome for the clients concerned lead to Partnering Achievements (PAs).



Regional business and innovation support structure

This term refers to the full set of arrangements that are in place in each region to support business development and innovation, in particular with regard to SMEs. [Network services](#) are expected to complement and tie in with the existing support offer in the region.

Regional integration

The Network is conceived as the European branch of business and innovation support available at national and regional level. Therefore, Network services must be embedded in the national, regional and local business support ecosystem. Ensuring coherence of the Network activities and their seamless integration in the regional environment is a priority and a strategic issue for all consortia. This also includes cooperation with other EU networks present in their region that provide services or outreach activities targeted at SMEs.

Regional integration means:

- Avoiding duplication and seeking complementarities and synergies with existing services and actions supporting SMEs in the regional or national ecosystem;
- Positioning the Network and its members through a thorough communication strategy, providing added value with a European dimension to SMEs in the regional support environment;
- Identifying and providing value-added services with a European dimension that fit into and complement the existing regional business and innovation support ecosystem and contribute to its quality. This includes systematically transferring good practices developed at the European level to stakeholders in the regions covered by the consortia;
- Planning regular [stakeholder](#) meetings to provide updates on current EU-related issues, Commission initiatives and services;
- Communicating and coordinating effectively at regional level, feeding actively into regional and macro-regional initiatives and strategies, such as the Smart Specialisation Strategies.

The overall goal is to increase synergies and improve the cost-effectiveness and [impact](#) on SMEs of Network service provision by involving [regional stakeholders](#) in joint activities.

Resilience

Resilience is the ability of a company to spot and understand upcoming challenges and shape its business with a view to withstanding and dealing with unexpected changes in their business environment, including for example supply chain disruptions or geopolitical changes.

Resilient companies can adapt their business practices to anticipate challenges they may come across and to benefit from any new business opportunities arising from changing trends, making informed strategic business decisions at the right time.

Resilience relies both on the skills of companies to manage change and innovation, and on diversification of their dependencies.

Network advisory and [partnering services](#) should be designed in such a way that client companies become aware of the economic importance of resilience and build skills as well as structures to increase their resilience to external developments. Network resilience support includes:

- Raising awareness amongst SMEs on the benefits of planning business practices in a resilient manner, focusing on anticipating potential disruptive trends;
- Integrating the resilience element into the intake assessments with SMEs to help them understand how to manage change and innovation with the purpose of reducing risks in their value chain;
- Providing related services that further support SMEs in this process, such as advice on access to finance, partnering and [technology transfer](#) services, advice on specific [Innovation management](#), etc;
- Making use of the tools available under the Supply Chain Resilience Platform, when applicable.



Sector group

Sector groups are groups of Network advisors with specific background and experience in a certain economic area (sector) who commit to work together to meet the specific needs of their clients operating in this sector. Sector groups represent a framework to plan and implement efficiently collaborative activities.

Members of the group can communicate via [CONNECT](#). They also meet to discuss activities either online or physically.

Signposting

Signposting occurs when a Network partner, after making full use of the [hub-and-spoke](#) model, is not able to deliver a service required by an SME. Typical situations include

cases where the SME is looking only for local opportunities without having any international ambitions, or when specific expertise in the Network is missing to respond to the request (rare, but hypothetically possible). Then the respective SME is directed to the most suitable business support provider outside the Network who could (better) address the client's needs.

Single Market

The common (single) market comprising all Member States of the European Union in which the free movement of goods, services, capital and persons is ensured and in which European citizens are free to live, work, study and do business.

For more information: https://ec.europa.eu/growth/single-market_en.

SME

Small and medium-sized enterprise under the definition of EU recommendation 2003/361.

For more information: https://ec.europa.eu/growth/smes/sme-definition_en.

SME Feedback

The Network is a key communication channel for SMEs to the European Commission (EC). Network partners gather feedback from SMEs on selected EU policies, actions and legislation, in response to specific priorities announced by the EC and complementing the role of other business organisations in this context. All consortia must nominate at least one SME feedback contact person.

SME feedback includes:

- contacting, informing, inviting and consulting SMEs in the framework of SME consultations launched through the Network.
- promoting on-line public consultations launched by the EC, and informing SMEs of evaluations, roadmaps and consultations on new EC initiatives that are likely to affect businesses.
- responding to ad-hoc feedback requests from the Commission, related to EU policies especially in the framework of impact assessments and evaluations;
- Collecting feedback on Single Market issues from SME clients and relaying it to the Commission via available feedback channels and/or [SOLVIT](#);
- Disseminating the results of this feedback in their region, when applicable.

Spoke

In the Network, a spoke is the entity that employs the Network advisor who contributes to an advanced advisory or partnering service provided to the client of a hub, the client's main contact point in the Network.

Staff exchange

A Staff Exchange programme is an opportunity for Network partners to gain and share experience, knowledge and ideas with each other. It contributes to improve the quality and the skills of the Network staff members, share good practices and information within the Network. Staff exchange supports less experienced Network partners or those who may lack skills in certain areas.

To apply, an organisation with one or more members interested in specific knowledge area should identify and contact Network colleagues in another organisation to agree on the potential activity – topic, terms, duration and roles. Network partners can apply as host or guest.

Once both sides agree, the host or the guest fills in and submits the online request form in LEARN, to be approved by [EISMEA](#).

Stakeholder

A regional or local stakeholder is any type of actor (including individual persons) located in a Network consortium's local or regional environment that is not a member of the consortium but with which it might collaborate within the framework of its activities.

Stakeholder agreement

An agreement (formal or informal, written or not) between a Network consortium and any number of stakeholders, outlining the relationship and possible areas of collaboration between a Network consortium and a stakeholder/group of stakeholders.

Steering and Advisory Group (SAG)

The role of the SAG is to:

- receive and disseminate information on strategic decisions for the Network made by the Commission and [EISMEA](#),
- inform and advise them about views and issues in the Network,
- provide feedback on changing needs or implementation difficulties and take a lead in implementing changes in the Network, acting as an interface with Network members in their respective countries.

This role involves constructive advice and feedback not just on operational issues but also on the implementation/application of EU legislation and regulation, as well as on policy decisions made by the Commission and how they can be translated into practical benefits for the EEN's SME clients.

Success stories / Story leads / Storytelling

In the Network client journey, when an Achievement is reached, the success of a client's case and the positive [impact](#) on its business is explained in a story.

- *Story lead*: story leads provide a brief description of a client case that concretely demonstrates the impact of [Network services](#) on the SME. They are used to assess whether a story has the potential of becoming a success story.
- *Success story*: success stories are built on story leads. They are promoted at Commission / Agency level, play a crucial role for the visibility of the Network and contribute strongly to making best use of the Network effect.

For more information: <https://een.ec.europa.eu/success-stories>

Sustainability

Network sustainability support services are meant to help SMEs in their transition to more sustainable business models and more resource-efficient, energy-efficient and circular processes and infrastructures. Sustainability should be a core consideration in all advisory and [partnering services](#) provided to SMEs, including awareness-raising and capacity-building services.

Network advisors should analyse which sustainability aspects are relevant within the context of a particular client journey, but Network services are expected to particularly focus on resource- and energy efficiency, circularity, clean production, renewable energies, environmental footprint as well as related legal/administrative obligations such as sustainability reporting.

The cross-cutting and broad nature of sustainability support implies that Network consortia are expected to make full use of the [hub-and-spoke](#) model to make specialised sustainability advice available to their clients. This implies that all Network advisors with sustainability competencies are expected to make these accessible within the Network (upon request), beyond the limits of their own consortium.

Sustainability support services are provided and coordinated within each Network consortium by the Sustainability Advisor(s). Given the complexity of sustainability challenges, Sustainability Advisors are encouraged to act as a coordinator of sustainability support services delivered by other actors within the concept of the [hub-and-spoke](#) model. They are also encouraged to draw on findings, results or resources developed in the context of other initiatives such as the Sustainability Partnership for SMEs projects run under the 2021 SMP COSME Work Programme.

Network consortia are expected to provide:

- Awareness-raising and information activities amongst SMEs on the challenges and opportunities of implementing sustainable business models and activities, including the environmental and social aspects of sustainability;
- Sustainability assessments taking place at the stage of the client needs assessment in the client journey;
- Dedicated [advisory services](#) based on the degree of awareness and willingness of the SME to engage in more sustainable business models and activities. This ranges from an introduction into the aims of a sustainable business approach to tailored [advisory services](#);
- Services that help SMEs understand and embrace the long-term benefits of the transition to more sustainable business models and activities, such as:
 - Advice on access to (public or private sources of) finance;
 - Partnering and [technology transfer](#) services;
- Advice on EU legislation and standards;
- Support for EU certification schemes such as the EU Ecolabel or EMAS;
- Advice on new sustainable business models, circular economy, green entrepreneurship, resource efficiency and clean energy – in cooperation with relevant service providers;
- Specific innovation support services, such as on eco-innovation and social innovation.
- Other specialised services with a strong sectoral focus.

To carry out the dedicated services, different assessment tools focusing on sustainability might be used.



Target group of the Network

The Network's target group are **European SMEs ready to scale their activities** in the Single Market and in [third countries](#), and with the ambition to improve and take a leading position through product, service or process innovation.

Some other types of organisations in the regional, national or local landscape may also receive Network support if the services provided to them are directly beneficial to the SMEs falling within the Network's scope.

Technology transfer

Transnational technology transfer is at the heart of Network activities and services that are provided to assist SMEs in transferring technologies across national and European borders. The aim is to foster innovation in SMEs by helping them adapt existing technologies or apply new ones so they can develop new products or services.

In the Network, technology transfer is the successful application or adaptation of an innovative technology from one organisation or industrial sector to another.

Thematic group

Thematic groups are formed around cross-cutting topics of concern to all Network consortia. They have for objective to create a better networking environment and to encourage contacts between experts in the Network on horizontal issues.

Members of the group can communicate via [CONNECT](#). They also meet to discuss activities either online or physically.

Third country

"Third countries" are defined as countries outside the European Union that do not participate in the [Single Market programme](#) (SMP). Third countries covered by the Network are all [non-EU countries indicated on the Network's website](#) minus the ones indicated as associated countries in this [European Commission document](#).



Variable geometry

The principle of variable geometry acknowledges the Network variety in terms of size of the consortia, interaction with the business support ecosystem and embeddedness in the host structures of the Network partners.



Working group

Working groups are temporary groups of Network staff members set up as and when required by the Agency to create common working standards, guidelines or tools for the benefit of the entire Network.

List of abbreviations

AA	Advisory Achievement
A2F	Access to funding and finance
AGA	Annotated Grant Agreement
B2B	Business to business
CRM	Client Relationship Management
DIQ	Digital Innovation Quotient
DoH	Declaration of Honour
EBPT	European Business Test Panel
EC	European Commission
EDIH	European Digital Innovation Hub
EEN	Enterprise Europe Network
EIC	European Innovation Council
EIT	European Institute of Technology
EISMEA	European Innovation Council and SME Executive Agency
EMAS	Eco-Management and Audit Scheme
EPA	Economic Partnership Agreement
ERDF	European Regional Development Fund
ESIF	European Structural and Investment Fund
EU	European Union
FAQ	Frequently Asked Questions
FTA	Free Trade Agreement
GA	Grant Agreement
IHC	Innovation Health Check
IP	Intellectual Property
IPR	Intellectual Property Rights
IT	Information Technology
KIC	Knowledge and Innovation Community
KPI	Key Performance Indicator
LEAR	Legal Entity Appointed Representative
NCP	National Contact Point
NUTS	Nomenclature of Territorial Units for Statistics
OCT	Overseas Countries and Territories
OJ	Official Journal
PA	Partnering Achievement

REA	Research Executive Agency
REACH	Registration, Evaluation, Authorisation and Restriction of Chemicals (EC Regulation)
SDG	Sustainable Development Goal
SME	Small- and Medium-sized Enterprises
SMP	Single Market Programme
TPO	Trade Promotion Organisation
TT	Technology transfer
UN	United Nations
VAT	Value Added Tax